Classic Mentaiko Pasta

by Namiko Hirasawa Chen

Japanese-style Mentaiko Pasta is one of the most popular wafu fusion dishes in Japan. In this quick and easy recipe, we toss hot spaghetti in a buttery cream sauce mixed with spicy salted cod or pollock roe. It's a heavenly, delicious combination! Ready in just 20 minutes.

Prep: 5 mins **Cook:** 15 mins **Total:** 20 mins

Servings: 2

Ingredients

- 2 Tbsp **Diamond Crystal kosher salt** (for boiling the pasta)
- 8 oz **spaghetti** (4 oz, 113 g per serving)
- 2 sacs **spicy salted pollock roe or cod roe (karashi mentaiko)** (about 1 sac (1 oz, 30 g) per serving; I use the kind without food coloring, so my dish does not look as pink/orange as other versions)
- 2 Tbsp **whole milk**
- 2 Tbsp **heavy (whipping) cream**
- 2 Tbsp **unsalted butter** (melted)
- 1 Tbsp **soy sauce**
- **freshly ground black pepper**

For the Toppings

- **shredded nori seaweed** (or cut a nori sheet into thin strips 2 inches (5 cm) long)
- **shiso leaves (perilla/ooba)**

Instructions

1. Gather all the ingredients.

2. Bring a large pot of water to a boil. Add **2 Tbsp Diamond Crystal kosher salt** to the boiling water and cook **8 oz spaghetti** until al dente, about 10 minutes (or according to the package instructions).

3. In a large bowl, combine **2 Tbsp whole milk**, **2 Tbsp heavy (whipping) cream**, **2 Tbsp unsalted butter**, and **1 Tbsp soy sauce**. Don't worry if the butter solidifies. The hot spaghetti will melt the butter later.

4. Add **freshly ground black pepper** and stir to combine.

5. Make a lengthwise slit in the membranes of **2 sacs spicy salted pollock roe or cod roe (karashi mentaiko)** to open. Squeeze out the roe from the sacs with your hands or a knife. Discard the membrane.

6. Add the roe to the bowl with the sauce ingredients and stir well.

7. When the spaghetti is done cooking, drain and transfer the pasta to the large bowl with the sauce.

8. Toss to combine until the butter is melted and the sauce evenly coats the pasta. Taste and adjust the seasoning with black pepper and kosher salt.

To Serve

1. Serve onto individual plates. Roll up a stack of **shiso leaves (perilla/ooba)** and cut them into thin strips. Garnish the Mentaiko Pasta with the julienned shiso and **shredded nori seaweed**. Enjoy!

To Store

1. Unfortunately, this dish doesn't reheat well from leftovers. If you reheat mentaiko, the fish eggs will overcook.

Nutrition

Calories: 664kcal, **Carbohydrates:** 88g, **Protein:** 23g, **Fat:** 24g, **Saturated Fat:** 12g, **Polyunsaturated Fat:** 3g, **Monounsaturated Fat:** 6g, **Trans Fat:** 1g, **Cholesterol:** 219mg, **Sodium:** 925mg, **Potassium:** 338mg, **Fiber:** 4g, **Sugar:** 4g, **Vitamin A:** 850IU, **Vitamin C:** 1mg, **Calcium:** 131mg, **Iron:** 5mg

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